



K O N I N K L I J K E N E D E R L A N D S E
A K A D E M I E V A N W E T E N S C H A P P E N

ACADEMY INSTITUTES
CoARA action plan 2024-2028

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1 CONTEXT: EXISTING FRAMEWORKS AND INITIATIVES

In November 2019, the Dutch universities as represented by the Association of Universities in the Netherlands (VSNU, now Universities of the Netherlands (UNL)), along with the Royal Netherlands Academy of Arts and Sciences (the Academy), the Dutch Research Council (NWO), the Netherlands Organisation for Health Research and Development (ZonMw) and the Netherlands Federation of University Medical Centres (NFU) published the position paper '[Room for everyone's talent](#)' – thereby launching the [national Recognition & Rewards Program](#) (R&R). All the institutions involved, including the Academy, committed to the following guiding principles:

- Diversification and vitalisation of career paths, thereby promoting excellence in each of the key areas of academia.
- Acknowledgement of both the independence and individual talents and aspirations of academics and team performance.
- An emphasis on quality of work over output metrics (such as number of publications).
- Encouragement of all aspects of open science.
- Encouragement of high-quality academic leadership.

Each of the organisations involved has set up committees to work towards a broader system of recognition and rewards in academia and for academic staff. They coordinate their efforts regularly at the national level to ensure a common pathway. In April 2023, the road map [Room for everyone's talent in practice](#) was published. In the road map, the stakeholders use the five priorities from the position paper to indicate what they want to achieve in the coming years.

The guiding principles of the position paper 'Room for everyone's talent' were also incorporated in the national protocol that is used to evaluate the quality of research conducted at Dutch universities and the Academy and NWO institutes. Committees of Dutch and international experts and peers evaluate research units and institutes through review visits. The evaluation criteria and procedures are described in the Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP). The revised SEP ([SEP 2021-2027](#)) that was published in 2020, facilitates a broader system of recognition and rewards by basing the evaluation on the research units' own goals and strategy and focusing less on numerical data. Research units determine for themselves which indicators they consider relevant for evaluation of the unit's research. Evaluation committees will no longer assign scores in their report, instead they provide a critical substantive opinion and recommendations for the future.

The vision that a reform of assessment of research, researchers and research organisations is needed, is not limited to The Netherlands. In September 2022 [the European 'Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment'](#) officially opened for signature. The agreement was co-created with over 350+ organisations from 40 countries and by now signed by 600+ organisations. The European 'Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment' endorses the objectives of the national Recognition & Rewards programme. In October 2022, UNL, each of the fourteen individual universities in The Netherlands, the Academy, NWO, and NFU signed the agreement and became a member of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA). By signing the European 'Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment' the Academy committed to prepare an action plan that translates the commitments in the Agreement into activities that contribute to a reform of the assessment of research and researchers at the Academy institutes.

2 RECOGNITION & REWARDS AT THE ACADEMY

The Academy is both a learned society and an organisation of national research institutes. The Academy's duties – in brief – are: to serve as a learned society representing the full spectrum of scientific and scholarly disciplines; to act as a management body for national research institutes; to advise the Dutch Government on matters related to scientific pursuit.

The Academy translated the guiding principles in the position paper 'Room for everyone's talent' into the [Recognition & Rewards Agenda 2022-2025](#) for the Academy institutes, that was published in January 2022. In its effort to fulfil the commitments outlined in the European 'Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment', the Academy has developed this action plan. Given the overlap with the objectives of the national Recognition & Rewards programme, many of the activities listed below are also included in the Academy's Recognition & Rewards Agenda 2022-2025. The Academy's Recognition & Rewards Agenda and the CoARA action plan both focus on the Academy institutes. It considers objectives and actions to reform the assessment of research units the assessment of staff members.

3 COMMITMENTS AND ACTIONS

	Commitment in the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment	State of play at the Academy in July 2024	Objectives and actions 2024-2028
1	Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.	Diversity of careers: a) Some institutes have drafted staffing plans using the strategy and objectives of the institute as a guiding principle. b) Some institutes have described several distinct career paths based on the Recognition and Rewards Programme and in line with the recently updated UFO job profiles c) In Q4 2023 the Academy's vision Appreciative Leadership was published. Diversity of contributions: d) Institutes have started developing new indicators to monitor research performance in preparation for their next research evaluation using the Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP) 2021-2027. e) Stimulating Open Science: development of KNAW Roadmap Open Science in 2021, launch of KNAW Digital Competence Center in 2021 to strengthen the support for researchers for FAIR-data, participation in the national Regieorgaan Open Science.	Diversity of careers: a) Use experience that some institutes gained on drafting staffing plans for development of staffing plans at all (larger) institutes. b) Further investigate the development of differentiated career paths at all institutes for academic and research support staff. c) Implementation of the Appreciative Leadership vision. Diversity of contributions: d) Open Science: The KNAW Roadmap Open Science will be updated (starting in Q3 2024) and the Digital Competence Center will continue to develop. e) The Academy will apply for funding at NWO to improve on the rewarding and recognition of open science activities of staff members. See also actions listed under commitment 2.
2	Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	a) Institutes with tenure and career tracks have adjusted assessment criteria to align them with the Recognition and Rewards Programme b) In 2024 SEP 2021-2027 will be used for the first time at the Academy: six Academy institutes will be assessed by an evaluation committee using this protocol. c) Via participation in the national working group Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP), the Academy contributed to the	a) Design of a new interview format for all the various types of interviews (including the annual consultation). b) An analysis will be performed in Q3 2024 on the qualitative and quantitative indicators that were used by the six institutes in the self-evaluation reports that were prepared for the six SEP-evaluations in 2024. The Academy's R&R steering committee and the Institute

		development of SEP 2021-2027 and will continue to contribute to a successful implementation of the SEP 2021-2027 including the alignment with Recognition and Rewards Programme.	Director's council will discuss to what extent these indicators meet the R&R guiding principles and which further steps need to be developed for responsible use of metrics in future research assessment and in monitoring progress as part of the regular quality assurance cycle. c) The Academy will continue to participate in the national working group Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP) and will play an active role in evaluating SEP 2021-2027 and drafting SEP 2027-2033 including the alignment with R&R.
3	Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	a) The Academy disabled the option to display the h-index on the public portal of its Research Information System (Pure). Appropriate alternatives to the JIF (such as the Source Normalized Impact per Paper (SNIP) or Field Weighted Citation Impact (FWCI) are available, and institutes are encouraged to use these. b) In April 2019, the Academy signed the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA), a global initiative that aims to reduce dependence on bibliometric indicators in the evaluation of research and researchers and increase the use of other criteria. c) The research of the Academy institutes is evaluated every six years according to the national Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP). The most recent version of this protocol (SEP 2021-2027) states that the use of the Journal Impact Factor is not allowed. The use of individual bibliometric indicators such as the h-index is strongly discouraged.	a) The Academy will emphasize that alignment with R&R should continue to be a point of attention when drafting the SEP 2027-2033.
4	Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment.	The Academy institutes do not participate in rankings. Rankings are not used in assessments of staff or institutes.	N/A
5	Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	The Academy set up a R&R project organisation for 2022-2025 consisting of 1,2 fte: • 0.4 FTE HR project manager (includes 0.1 FTE for liaising with national programme team)	Project organisation after 2025: to be decided, depending on evaluation of the programme.

		• 0.4 FTE HR policy adviser / Centre for Career and Development (in kind) • 0.1 FTE policy adviser for Forum, Advisory and Research Department (in kind) • 0.1 FTE communication adviser (in kind) • 0.1 FTE secretarial/administrative project assistance • 0.1 FTE project committee chair: national representative and R&R advocate at Academy institute Many staff members are involved in short- and long-term projects related to R&R.	
6	Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	a) Research assessment criteria for the institutes are regularly discussed with the directors of the Academy institutes. In November 2021 prof. dr. De Rijcke (Leiden University) was invited to share her knowledge on translating strategy to relevant indicators, advantages and disadvantages of specific indicators and improving the process of continuous internal monitoring. b) In spring 2023 an analysis was performed and discussed in the Director's council of the progress made in translating the institutes' strategies to relevant indicators and in developing more qualitative indicators.	a) We will start a project on publication culture: who is listed as an author on publications, how do you recognize everyone's contribution if not through CRediT, are their different practices depending on the discipline? b) Based on the analysis listed under commitment 2 action 2, use of new tools will be considered as well as the possible development of guidelines for metrics and indicators.
7	Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	a) Staff is updated on recent developments related to R&R via newsletters, the external and internal websites. The interview series Humans of the Academy was launched in 2024 and draws attention to activities related to (among other things) R&R. b) The national working group Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP) organizes trainings and meetings on a regular basis for Academy and other staff involved in research assessments. c) The national online platform RRview plays an important role in exchanging best practices on R&R. The Academy's R&R project manager is an active contributor.	a) We will continue to share and update information on R&R and related topics on our new intranet (Portus). b) In 2024 an integral culture campaign plan was drafted to improve communication on themes such as leadership, social safety, Diversity & Inclusion and R&R. This will be further developed and implemented from 2025 onwards. c) The national working group Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP) and the national online platform RRview will continue to contribute to training and sharing best practices on R&R and related matters.
8	Exchange practices and	a) The Academy participates in the national program Recognition & Rewards. It has a steering committee, a	a) The national program Recognition & Rewards and RRview online platform will continue to play an important role.

	experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	committee of chairpersons and committee of project managers from the various participating institutions. The Academy participates at each of the three levels. b) The national R&R programme office together with the project managers and chairpersons organise activities, collect material, arrange meetings and act as a catalyst for this national movement, which is attracting interest from abroad.	b) A national working group on CoARA is being formed in which the Academy participates. An application for establishing a National Chapter will be considered.
9	Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments		a) Communication on CoARA will be included in the Academy's R&R communication strategy, see commitment 7. b) This action plan will be shared on Zenodo
10	Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	a) See the national road map Room for everyone's talent in practice. b) In June 2024, the results of the Culture Barometer Recognition & Rewards were released: a survey conducted among scientists in the Netherlands in early 2024.	a) In 2024 the Strategy Evaluation Protocol 2021-2027 will be evaluated. The results will be used when drafting SEP 2027-2033 including improved alignment with R&R. b) Progress on R&R will be monitored both at a national and institute level when implementing the roadmap and by repeating the Culture Barometer survey again (in year 2026)